

hour. Staffing requirements were reduced from 15 people to just two. The cost savings we achieved let us release new products and try new ways of doing things.”

Flipkart, Amazon, Facebook and Google are the best examples of what open source software usage can achieve. A survey published by Netcraft said that out of a total of 172 million websites, around 75 million used WordPress – an open source content management system. And out of these 75 million, 37.5 million used WordPress hosting.

Microsoft, which is the world’s largest licensed-source software provider, has acquired GitHub, an open source developers’ platform. This indicates open source software has a bright future.

What does the IBM-Red Hat and Microsoft-GitHub deal mean for OSS startups? Will there be more acquisitions?

The future of startups working on providing open source software solutions, at least for now, looks very promising. The recent IBM-Red Hat deal will make major players including Amazon, Microsoft and Google, find ways to strengthen their positions in the open source arena — some of their strategies will include acquiring startups that have already made a mark in the open source software services and support space.

The fact that a lot of big players were interested in acquiring GitHub before it was eventually bought by Microsoft suggests that the acquiring game is not yet over. Startups in the open source space should continue doing their best.

Similarly, the Red Hat acquisition by IBM, for a price that some claim to be six times Red Hat’s market value, indicates the importance big companies give to OSS.

Satya Nadella, CEO, Microsoft, wrote in a blog post: “Microsoft is all in on open source. We have been on a journey with open source, and today we are active in the open source ecosystem — we contribute to open source projects, and some of our most vibrant developer tools and frameworks are open source. When it comes to our commitment to open source, judge us by the actions we have taken in the recent past, our actions today, and in the future.”

But the way a startup looks at such big players also matters. If the prime aim of a startup developing OSS solutions and support is to get acquired by a big company, instead of creating world class solutions, then the supposed purpose of offering good solutions may be lost completely. It is a fact that an OSS solution speaks for itself and does not take much time to get noticed.

The focus should also be on long-term usage and benefits rather than on making profits instantly.

What makes open source software special?

Organisations across the world are turning to open source software to cut operational costs and increase profits. A survey by Black Duck Software and North Bridge pointed out that 78 per cent of all companies in the world use open

source software. Of these, 55 per cent use OSS because they think that it delivers superior security when lined up against proprietary solutions.

Net Friedman, CEO, GitHub, when explaining the importance of OSS on his personal blog, wrote, “Open source was the foundation of my career and some of my closest friendships; but it’s also the foundation of millions of products and ideas that only exist because you can get started by grabbing free code off the Internet. It’s actually hard to remember what the world was like before open source became widespread. Creating something new used to mean that your first step was to build or buy your baseline infrastructure. That’s gone today, and with every new piece of open source, the price of admission gets closer to zero.”

Open source software offers anyone the flexibility to modify code to fit specific needs, ranging from security patching to measuring vulnerabilities within hours. Additionally, OSS is free and support options are available at prices that are much lower than commercial products. A government that uses a proprietary software product usually ends up paying millions of dollars a year to the vendor. However, with open source software, it only pays for the support, thus saving a large chunk of money.

How will 5G impact OSS?

5G, which is touted to be a 100 times faster than LTE and 10 times faster than 4G, will help unlock the potential of OSS to its maximum extent. The network speeds will be faster than ever, allowing cloud platforms to function with virtually no lag at all. The support systems will get better over time, allowing real-time diagnosis of errors.

In fact, 5G may induce more institutions, governments and companies to adopt OSS as their preferred working platforms. The cost of operations will dramatically come down and will result in increased profits.

Developers around the world will get to share insights and developments related to code and solutions much faster. As a result, OSS platforms will penetrate deeper into all verticals and aspects of everyday life. This will have a positive effect on technologies used in agriculture, health, trading, financial services, IT, communications and more.

But 5G will also raise some challenges. Rajarshi Bhattacharyya, country head at SUSE, explains, “With 5G, telecom service providers will require service and network orchestration. And operators may need service life cycle management tools that complement service orchestration, and configuration management tools that support their network orchestrators. The Linux Foundation’s ONAP project is key to all the operators. Today, the adoption of microservices and Kubernetes is an important part of the DevOps and automation journey. Open Source MANO (a management and orchestration software stack), run by the European Telecommunications Standards Institute (ETSI), is also key to 5G.”